

Psalm 17

Hear the Right

Hear the right, O Lord, attend unto my cry
KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *Hear the right, O LORD, attend unto my cry, give ear unto my prayer, that goeth not out of feigned lips.*
- 2 *Let my sentence come forth from thy presence; let thine eyes behold the things that are equal.*
- 3 *Thou hast proved mine heart; thou hast visited me in the night; thou hast tried me, and shalt find nothing; I am purposed that my mouth shall not transgress.*
- 4 *Concerning the works of men, by the word of thy lips I have kept me from the paths of the destroyer.*
- 5 *Hold up my goings in thy paths, that my footsteps slip not.*
- 6 *I have called upon thee, for thou wilt hear me, O God: incline thine ear unto me, and hear my speech.*
- 7 *Shew thy marvellous lovingkindness, O thou that savest by thy right hand them which put their trust in thee from those that rise up against them.*
- 8 *Keep me as the apple of the eye, hide me under the shadow of thy wings,*
- 9 *From the wicked that oppress me, from my deadly enemies, who compass me about.*
- 10 *They are inclosed in their own fat: with their mouth they speak proudly.*
- 11 *They have now compassed us in our steps: they have set their eyes bowing down to the earth;*
- 12 *Like as a lion that is greedy of his prey, and as it were a young lion lurking in secret places.*
- 13 *Arise, O LORD, disappoint him, cast him down: deliver my soul from the wicked, which is thy sword:*
- 14 *From men which are thy hand, O LORD, from men of the world, which have their portion in this life, and whose belly thou fillest with thy hid treasure: they are full of children, and leave the rest of their substance to their babes.*
- 15 *As for me, I will behold thy face in righteousness: I shall be satisfied, when I awake, with thy likeness.*

2 · CONTEXT

A prayer of David under pressure from violent enemies, Psalm 17 combines a bold plea for vindicated integrity with vivid imagery of predatory attackers and a closing hope of beholding God's face in righteousness. Henry notes the balance between confident self-examination—inviting God to test his heart and find nothing amiss—and humble dependence, since the plea for justice is never separated from prayer for God's protecting care, pictured as the shadow of His wings and the apple of His eye.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

David asks God to hear a righteous cause, to let judgment come from His presence, having tried his heart and visited him in the night, finding no wickedness and no false purpose in his mouth. The opening establishes a plea of tested integrity, not self-righteous denial.

Verse 4-5

He has kept himself from the paths of the destroyer by the word of God's lips; his steps have been held up in God's paths, so that his footsteps have not slipped. Guarded conduct is credited to divine help, not mere willpower.

Verse 6-9

A direct call for God to hear and show His marvelous lovingkindness, saving those who trust Him from those who rise up. The famous image—"keep me as the apple of the eye," hide me "under the shadow of thy wings"—pictures tender, watchful protection from wicked oppressors who compass him about.

Verse 10-12

The attackers are described as enclosed in their own fat (self-satisfied pride), speaking proudly, tracking him like a lion eager to tear, lurking in secret places. The vivid predator imagery names real danger without denying it.

Verse 13-15

A closing petition: arise, Lord, disappoint the enemy, deliver from men whose portion is only in this life. David contrasts their satisfied children and store of wealth with his own hope: "as for me, I will behold thy face in righteousness: I shall be satisfied, when I awake, with thy likeness"—a hope reaching beyond present circumstances.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

Confident prayer for justice can coexist with humble dependence on God’s protecting care; ultimate satisfaction is found not in this life’s portion of wealth and comfort but in beholding God’s face and being made like Him.

Application for life today.

Invite God to test your own heart honestly, as David does, rather than only rehearsing others’ faults. When you feel hunted or outmatched by opposition, pray specifically for the “shadow of thy wings” protection rather than manufacturing your own defenses. And measure your life’s ultimate satisfaction not by “portion in this life” but by the hope of beholding God’s face and being conformed to His likeness.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What would it look like to invite God to try your heart honestly this week, as David does in verses 1–3?

2. Where do you currently need to pray for the protection pictured in “the shadow of thy wings”?

3. How does the hope of verse 15—being satisfied with God’s likeness—reshape your definition of a successful life?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, Commentary on the Whole Bible (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).